

U-TURN ON NUCLEAR ISSUE

The Big Bang

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

The BJP's opposition to the deal was charted at several core group meetings at Vajpayee's home. It was decided to field Sinha and Shourie instead of the pro-US Jaswant Singh to explain the party's view. In a statement, the duo concluded, "The agreement is an assault on our nuclear sovereignty... We are unable to accept the agreement as finalised." And BJP joined the Left and UNPA in opposing the deal with Advani ringing up Prakash Karat for coordination in Parliament.

But recently, Advani attended a meeting comprising right leaning writers, professionals and the odd security expert. It was at this meeting of non-BJP members that he was persuaded about the impact an anti-US stance might have on the BJP's votebank and to do a rethink. While agreeing that the current deal was between "unequals", Advani deviated from the party line by offering a way out. He pointed out that if the Government could bring an amendment in the Atomic Energy Act to protect India's strategic independence then "there is no problem with the 123 Agreement". Unlike his Jinnah comments, Advani may even have got some support for his pro-US view, as there are few partymen who are uncomfortable at being clubbed with the Left, if only he had taken them into confidence and worked out a new roadmap. After all, it is BJP that is the architect of the Indo-US alliance.

Ever since the reins of BJP passed into Rajnath's hands, Vajpayee has taken on an advisory role, a sort of elder statesman who dispenses advice whenever it is sought. But Advani has made it clear that he is not keen to limit himself to just being a hands off patriarch. It takes various forms: sometimes the simple ploy of stealing the limelight away from Rajnath's team at the party office by issuing press releases from his residence that overshadow the official briefing of the day or a more public snub like the one he delivered at the recent national executive meet where he criticised him for the Uttar Pradesh debacle.

Advani has also been rebuilding his own team of loyalists at the party headquarters. All those who had deserted him after the Jinnah controversy and had even written his political obituary have come

back to him. Advani's core group, however, is outside BJP, consisting of urban public school elite who function via thinktanks and meetings at private homes instead of the party headquarters. Even when he was party chief, Advani preferred to work from his home rather than the BJP office.

Rajnath's style is a study in contrast. Unlike some of the former party chiefs, he is yet to build a conference hall and hold office-bearers' meetings at his home. Importantly, he

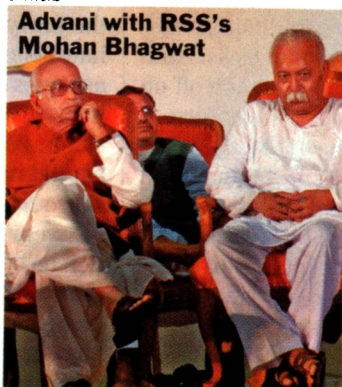
sees the rural voter rather than the urban elite as the party's traditional votebank. Some of his colleagues laughed at him for holding a farmers' rally in the middle of the nuclear crisis, but he went ahead nevertheless. Not too eloquent in English, he does not resort to literary quotes to emphasise his point, but settles for wry humour. When some Advani acolytes sneeringly referred to him as a mere regional leader, he countered by mocking at Delhi's political culture talk where a man with roots in India's most populous state is seen as a regional leader while someone with absolutely no political roots anywhere becomes a national leader. His constituency is the grass-roots worker rather than the television anchor. Statistics show that the argument that BJP was losing its urban votebank in opposing the deal is somewhat skewed since it had already lost it



FINEST HOUR: Vajpayee at Pokhran in 1998

Kept in dark, BJP struggled to explain the change in Advani's stance. Sushma Swaraj claimed that this was not a turnaround and that by asking to make the Indian laws stronger, Advani had in fact jeopardised the deal. Worse was to follow. An Advani confidante told the media that Mohan Bhagwat had called Advani soon after his comments and supported his change of stance. An aghast RSS rushed to clarify that it did not agree with Advani. "We stand by the resolution passed at our Pratinidhi Sabha in February 2006," said an RSS spokesperson. Not quite an endorsement of Advani's line.

SIPRA DAS



RSS got upset after one of Advani's aides misrepresented a private conversation to the media.